

# Plants for formal and modern designs

Formal gardens conform to a symmetrical plan, while modern designs follow an asymmetrical format, but both can employ similar plants.

Closely clipped hedging is a common feature in formal designs and is used to carve out screens, parterres, and knot gardens. Boxwood and yew are traditional choices, but you can also try boxleaf honeysuckle to update the look. Modern designs often include blocks of leafy plants, such as bamboo, grasses, or hebe, to produce graphic slabs of color and texture. Also popular are pleached trees, where the stems are left bare and the branches trained horizontally to produce a slim hedge on stilts—the littleleaf linden can be used to create this effect. Use flowers sparingly to add splashes of seasonal color.



SHRUB SMALL

## *Buxus sempervirens* 'Suffruticosa'

**COMMON BOXWOOD** A slow-growing evergreen shrub with small, oval green leaves that are ideal for clipping into topiary and architectural shapes. Grow in a large pot or use as a low hedge or bed edging.  $\uparrow$ 3ft (1m)  $\leftrightarrow$  5ft (1.5m)

☹️ ☀️ 🌞 🌿 🚫 Z6–8



TREE MEDIUM

## *Laurus nobilis*

**BAY LAUREL** This evergreen tree has stems of dark green aromatic leaves that can be clipped into shapes to form topiary. Grow in a sheltered area, and plant in large containers of soil-based potting mix or as a centerpiece in a parterre.  $\uparrow$ 40ft (12m)  $\leftrightarrow$  30ft (10m)

☹️ ☀️ 🌞 Z8–10



SHRUB SMALL

## *Hebe topiaria*

**HEBE** A rounded evergreen shrub with dense stems of small gray-green leaves that are ideal for clipping, and clusters of small white summer flowers. Use it to edge a formal geometric bed or as a small topiary specimen. Best in West Coast gardens.  $\uparrow$ 24in (60cm)  $\leftrightarrow$  3ft (1m)

☹️ ☀️ 🌞 Z8–10



SHRUB MEDIUM

## *Hydrangea macrophylla*

**BIGLEAF HYDRANGEA** This compact deciduous shrub has broad oval leaves and clusters of small fertile and larger sterile blooms in pink, blue, or white. It makes an elegant mid-bed plant or edging for a path.

$\uparrow$ 5ft (1.5m)

☹️ ☀️ 🌞 🚫 Z6–9

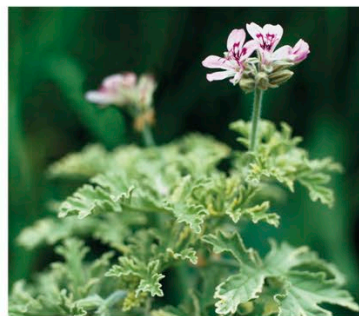


SHRUB MEDIUM

## *Lonicera nitida*

**BOXLEAF HONEYSUCKLE** This bushy evergreen shrub, with arching stems of tiny dark green leaves, is used as a compact knee- or waist-high hedge. It can also be trimmed into topiary shapes. 'Baggesen's Gold' (above) has golden foliage.  $\uparrow$ 6ft (2m)  $\leftrightarrow$  10ft (3m)

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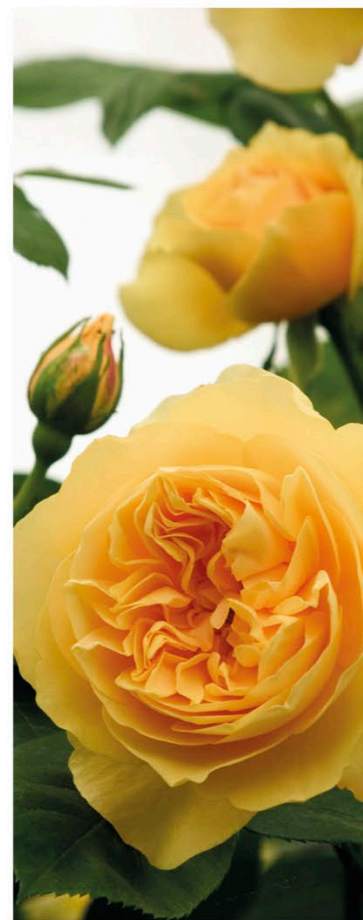


PERENNIAL SMALL

## *Pelargonium* 'Lady Plymouth'

**SCENTED GERANIUM** Grown as an annual, this spreading perennial has eucalyptus-scented silver-margined green leaves. In summer, lavender-pink flower clusters appear. Grow in an urn in a parterre.  $\uparrow$ 16in (40cm)  $\leftrightarrow$  8in (20cm)

☹️ ☀️ 🚫 Z10–11



SHRUB SMALL

## *Rosa* GRAHAM THOMAS

**ENGLISH SHRUB ROSE** A shrub rose or short climber with disease-resistant green leaves and cup-shaped, highly fragrant, yellow fully double blooms from summer to fall. Grow in a rose bed underplanted with geraniums or on an arch.  $\uparrow$ 4ft (1.2m)  $\leftrightarrow$  5ft (1.5m)

☹️ ☀️ Z5–9